having been breached, the ad hoc platoon along with Lieutenant Pahwa decided to make a break for it.

The mobile column had barely covered four kilometres when news came through that the Chinese had attacked Bomdila. The column commander immediately ordered his troops back. As the two tanks tried to reverse in the narrow space, the column came under fire from Chinese jitter parties from the ridge to the left of the road. Though the mobile column at this stage had suffered no casualties, it was already too late, as the Chinese had infiltrated and occupied the Sikh LI defences in reasonable strength. The column was now caught in the open, and the Sikh LI troops turned tail and ran. Gurbax Singh and a couple of other officers came out of their office and tried to stop the troops, but to no avail. With the Indian soldiers out of the way, 6 Field Regiment Battery and the mountain guns began firing over open sights at the erstwhile Sikh LI defences, while the two 7 Cavalry tanks also opened up with their Vickers Browning MMGs and main guns. With the Chinese pinned down in the bunkers, the tanks then took up position in the Circuit House area to guard all approaches from the west.

With 1 Sikh LI having decamped, the only infantry troops left with Gurbax Singh were 1 Madras deployed on the right flank of Bomdila. Until that point, it had been bypassed by the Chinese altogether. Unfortunately, communication between 1 Madras and Brigade HQ had snapped somewhere along the line. Left without any troops to flush out the Chinese and shaken by 1 Sikh LI's flight, the brigade commander got into his jeep and drove off towards Tenga. Shortly thereafter, the rest of the brigade staff followed suit. No clear instructions were issued; word of mouth messages let it be known that a general withdrawal had been sounded.

The guns continued to pound the erstwhile 1 Sikh LI positions for the next two hours. The surviving Chinese either decamped into the hills or just lay low in the bunkers. Having exhausted their ammunition, 6 Field Regiment Battery and the tanks withdrew towards Tenga. Through all this, 1 Madras remained oblivious of the fact that part of Bomdila had been abandoned. By 3 p.m., there was a deadly silence over Bomdila, with the Chinese sweeping the area with sporadic MMG fire every now and then. To all outward appearances, Bomdila had fallen.